

private equity and venture capitalists are looking for models that offer flexible pricing based on the actual value creation for the customers, which is measurable and replicable.

The industry is expected to witness partnership among various participants in the ecosystem, such as AI and Big Data service providers, who might partner with OEMs, system integrators, and large enterprise customers with hardware capabilities.

Innovation is going to be the prime focus of the start-ups and the enterprises as well in order to build a sustainable partnership among the eco-system participants. The large corporate houses can turn out to be the initial investors in the start-ups. The start-up companies are shifting their focus on data analytics software and communication capabilities in order to develop solutions which can be patented and, at the same time, are commercially viable.

The entrepreneurs look for long-term investors, who understand the technology.

Faster commercialisation and revenue generation through small contracts can help the small businesses in developing a clear-cut use case in a particular industry. Such proven track record can help them find the investors. Humanitarian services can be the trigger point to draw attention of policy makers and investors. To compete globally, the Indian firms can focus on software, system integration, high-value low-volume ecosystem, such as purpose-built border security, and disaster management. The commercial viability will be mainly driven by the application suitability of the solutions across a large number of use cases across the globe.

Future outlook

The UAV technology is going to be an enabler in implementing bigger

ideas of advancement of the mankind including smart cities, EV charging, supply chain management, and precision farming, etc. The United Nations has estimated that by the year 2050, 68% of the world population will be living in urban areas. This projection is bound to put pressure on increasing the efficiency in town planning and resource allocation. Urban local bodies/municipal corporations are expected to induct UAV technologies for geo-spatial survey and geographical information systems, which, in turn, would help them plan the infrastructure development for smart cities in a shorter time span.

Precision farming is the future of Indian agriculture, where drones will be deployed for aerial survey for water resource planning, crop spraying, dusting, monitoring, and crop insurance, etc. The supply chain management is going to deploy drones for inventory management using RFID, QR code, and IoT technologies for warehouse monitoring, and delivery of goods as well.

Amazon has patented a wireless EV charging technology that can charge the batteries on the move, which is going to be a game changer if it is rolled out on a mass scale in future in India. Amazon has already taken initiative in this direction. In 2017, it filed a patent for a technology which encompasses delivering energy using an autonomous vehicle. The technology involves a drone carrying a charged battery to an electric vehicle, docking autonomously with it, and charging it.

Miniaturisation of drones and the possibility of equipping drones with solar panels, though at very experimental stage, can be the next level of evolution. The future is bright for the UAV technology in India on the backdrop of fast-growing use cases of the technology across a large number of industries. **EFY**

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